talent and widely divergent destinies to Akbar's court. '[W]e were . . . loaves out of the same oven,' wrote the first of them, Abdul Qadir Badauni, whose acerbic account of Akbar's reign and personality, written in bitter secrecy, has regaled its readers ever since its publication.[1] The second loaf was Badauni's eternal – he would say infernal – nemesis: Abul Fazl, historian, hagiographer and most devoted of Akbar's courtiers. Unlike Badauni's secret diary, Abul Fazl's account of Akbar, his dynasty and his reign was the most celebrated book of its time, commissioned by the emperor himself, lavishly illustrated and presented as 'the code of regulations of the outer and inner world and the duties of sovereignty and servitude for all mankind from the king to the beggar'.[2] The *Akbarnama* remains the most comprehensive account of Akbar and his times, and its author would pay a great price for such intimate access to his powerful subject's life.

On the face of it, Badauni was the more experienced of the two when they came to Akbar's court. He was older, possibly in his early to mid-thirties; old enough to recall Hemu's siege tactics, and to have witnessed, first-hand, Pir Muhammad's carnage in Malwa. Unlike Abul Fazl, Badauni wasn't applying for his first job.

Most recently, he had been employed by a man of simple-minded bigotry called Husain Khan – nicknamed 'Tukriya' because he had once mistaken a Hindu for a Muslim and risen to greet him. Distraught by his faux pas, Husain Khan, then governor of Lahore,[3] ordered Hindus under his administration to wear a 'tukra', a piece, of coloured cloth on their sleeves to prevent any further lapses into good manners on his part.

There were few matters on which Husain Khan was not equally inflexible. He believed nuts were intoxicating, for example, and banned them.[4] He spent years of his life in an obsessive campaign to conquer the hill kingdoms north of Punjab and raid their temples, which were, he believed, built with bricks of silver and gold.

Another of his obsessions had been to capture Mirza Ibrahim, who had just escaped the prickly pears of Sarnal and was on his way to Punjab. Husain Khan and his men, including Badauni, went galloping after him, but it was Husain Quli who reached Ibrahim first. Husain Khan descended upon the battlefield with much fanfare, 'eighty or ninety men, and drums